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Lake after lake

With the data centre space set to see a flurry of refreshes we sit down with Rajeeb Hazra to gain insight into Intel's DC strategy

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d From an Indian context, does Intel have to come up with specific solutions to target this market?
Rajeeb: We build products that have capabilities to be deployed worldwide. When you're talking about a Xeon processor, that's basically a general purpose CPU, that you can run an Indian ISV's code or some MNC ISV's code, to workload optimised silicon like an accelerator or some of our FPGAs. We tend to build general purpose or workload targeted programmable solutions, and we're trying to get as much leverage. Our work very specific to India's needs. India has some specific needs because, in some cases, whether it's a combination of, the actual problem itself, the regulatory environment, the constraints around the use of technology, the workforce maturity, and all of those things, these drive towards a different set of solutions or different ways to use solution. And there we participate with our local partners and customers in customising the solutions for India.

d Is this where the specialised SKUs come in? Also, was Cascade Lake the first family to have such specialisations?
Rajeeb: What we do is we, hyper-specialise for workload support, not so much for geography. Our 2nd Gen Xeon scalable has very specific enhancements, which we call Deep Learning Boosts or DL-Boost for AI training and inference. We have SKUs that have enhanced memory bandwidth, which we call the Platinum Series for high memory bandwidth application or high performance computing. We have SKUs that deal with the means of networks as well. So we build for workloads that need specialisation.

d You already have different pricing within the SKU stack such as the Bronze, Silver, Gold and Platinum series, and then you have more function-based specialisation i.e. the high-bandwidth memory SKUs and the NFV SKUs. When you further diversify your portfolio to this extent, wouldn't consumers be confused as to which SKU they should go for?
Rajeeb: It could if we stopped at simply making the SKUs and saying, "Have at it!" Part of the work here is to actually to build solutions around these basic ingredients. So for instance, our goal with Intel Select Solutions is to actually demystify that. If you want an SAP HANA solution, or you want a VMware solution, we pre-validate and say that this is the configuration you need.

d If you look at the server segment, you have launches happening with a wider launch window because consumers tend not to upgrade that frequently. However, in 2020 we see two launches, Cooper Lake and Ice Lake, back to back with about six months between them. So what's that strategy change for?
Rajeeb: It's a really simple statement of our strategy – you have to keep innovation at the rate of our customers. And our customers are no longer just OEMs. There are cloud service providers who are more than happy to take the latest generation technology. So I think it's not so much of a strategy change as it is, to say, when you have the right product out in the marketplace, put it out. Since the market is moving so much faster moving today, if you have a valid piece of technology that delivers a value proposition, the market will accept it. So our goal is to introduce innovation at the rate in which our customers need and then ease the challenges with things like higher level of integration and greater support.

d Server hardware is a lot more expensive. Would six months be enough for one provider to break even on the investment to even consider refreshing again?
Rajeeb: This would be a very fair question, only if both products are equivalent or replacements.

d They're both Whitley, right?
Rajeeb: They're both on the same base platform so that eases the challenge a little bit. Obviously, there's still extra validation that you have to do every time we get a new processor even if it's the same base platform. So that's one reason why we believe we can introduce new processors or innovations quicker by keeping the same platform for longer. Also Cooper Lake and Ice Lake are targeted for diverse usages. Our workloads and users have expanded. So, we believe that Ice Lake will serve a certain portion of the workload space and Cooper Lake will stand on its on. d